

Beyond Algorithms: How Platform Structures and Communication Cultures Shape Political Trust on Social Media in South Korea and the United States

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I. Research Problem and Motivation

The global decline of trust in traditional media has fundamentally altered the information landscape of democratic societies. In this context, politicians in both South Korea and the United States have increasingly turned to social media platforms to bypass conventional journalistic gatekeeping and communicate directly with voters. Yet the assumption that this process unfolds uniformly across different national contexts deserves critical scrutiny.

South Korea and the United States present a particularly compelling comparative case. The two countries share democratic institutions and high levels of internet penetration, yet diverge markedly in their dominant platforms, algorithmic ecosystems, and communicative cultures. A “YouTube-centric” ecosystem characterizes South Korea’s digital landscape, whereas the United States features a highly fragmented landscape of X, TikTok, and podcast networks. These are not merely technical differences; they reflect deeper divergences in how trust is socially constructed and institutionally mediated in each society.

The existing literature on political social media use has largely treated platform adoption and cultural context as separate variables. Studies of political communication in South Korea have examined Twitter and YouTube usage patterns (Park, 2013), while American scholarship has focused on presidential campaigning online (Jungherr, 2016) and social media’s role in civic engagement (Boulianne, 2015). Following the logic of Fletcher et al. (2025), who examined trust through the structural shift from TV to social media, this research investigates how these distinct platform architectures interact with High-Context (Korea) and Low-Context (U.S.) cultures to shape political credibility.

Researcher's Positionality

My research interest in media trust stems from my academic background in journalism and my personal experience living in both Korea and the U.S. Having observed the different ways people engage with political communication in both countries, I aim to provide a more nuanced analysis of the current media landscape.

II. Research Questions

This study is guided by one central research question and four subsidiary questions:

Main Research Question

How do platform structures and cultural contexts jointly shape the process by which politicians become trusted information sources in South Korea and the United States?

RQ 1: How does the centralized YouTube-dominated structure in South Korea facilitate different trust-building patterns compared to the fragmented platform ecosystem (X, TikTok, Podcasts) in the United States?

RQ 2: How do High-Context (Korea) and Low-Context (United States) communication norms dictate the form of social media content and the specific "trust cues" evaluated by audiences?

RQ 3: In cases where politicians adopt influencer-style communication practices (personal disclosure, direct address, daily vlogging), how does the mechanism of trust transfer differ between the two countries?

RQ 4: How does the shift toward these platform structures reshape existing media credibility hierarchies and contribute to the "News Finds Me" perception in both nations?

III. Theoretical Framework

This study draws on five theoretical traditions that together form an explanatory model of cross-national political trust on social media. The framework is organized around the central argument that trust formation cannot be adequately explained by any single variable; rather, it emerges from the interaction of platform structural affordances, cross-cultural communication norms, and the qualitatively distinct ways audiences relate to news institutions.

1) Parasocial Interaction (Horton & Wohl, 1956): Describes the “one-sided intimacy” developed between audiences and media personas; applied to analyze how politicians-as-influencers build relational trust through personal disclosure and perceived authenticity on various platforms.

2) High/Low-Context Culture (Hall, 1976): Examines differences between implicit and explicit communication styles. In this study, it is applied to explore how trust cues are encoded and interpreted

differently across cultural contexts. While South Korean audiences may be more attuned to relational and implicit signals (e.g., perceived sincerity or social context), U.S. audiences may place relatively greater emphasis on explicit and information-based cues. However, these differences are not absolute and may vary depending on platform norms and generational factors.

3) Media Environment Shifts (Fletcher et al., 2025): Provides a structural framework for understanding how the global transition from television to social media systematically erodes institutional trust, prioritizing observable media environments over hidden algorithmic processes.

4) News Finds Me (NFM) Perception (Goyanes et al., 2023): Explains the belief that important information will reach one passively through social networks; used to analyze how audiences delegate trust decisions to platform structures, often substituting politicians for journalists.

5) Media Distrust vs. Cynicism (Markov & Min, 2023): Distinguishes between distrust as a conditional and evaluative skepticism toward journalism, and cynicism as a more generalized and stable negative orientation. This distinction helps explain whether audiences remain open to journalistic correction or instead turn to alternative sources of authority, such as politicians, as competing epistemic communities.

Why These Theories? Connecting Course Readings to the Research

Markov & Min (2023) offer a crucial conceptual distinction that sharpens this study's central concept of 'trust.' Their finding that distrust is a nuanced, correctable perception whereas cynicism is a deterministic rejection allows us to ask not just whether audiences trust political social media content, but in what mode they distrust it. This distinction is especially productive comparatively: Korean audiences steeped in a high-context culture of group loyalty may exhibit different cynicism thresholds than American audiences accustomed to explicit institutional critique.

Goyanes et al. (2023) further complicate the picture by showing that the 'News Finds Me (NFM)' perception, the belief that important information will reach one passively through social networks, is one of the strongest longitudinal predictors of news avoidance, stronger than overload or distrust alone. Applied to political social media, NFM helps explain why heavy social media users in both countries may delegate trust decisions to algorithmic feeds, creating the conditions under which politicians can substitute for journalists as trusted sources.

Fletcher et al. (2025) provide the macro-level scaffolding: across 46 countries, as media environments shift from television to social media, trust in news systematically declines, yet the mechanisms differ by country context, aligning with our cross-national comparative design

The central theoretical contribution of this study is that platform structures, cultural contexts, and modes of audience distrust are mutually constitutive rather than independent variables.

In South Korea, a YouTube-dominant platform environment interacts with a high-context culture that places emphasis on relational cues and shared social meanings. Building on Markov & Min (2023), audiences exhibiting higher levels of cynicism toward mainstream media may become less receptive to

journalistic authority and more likely to engage with alternative sources, such as political actors on YouTube, as competing epistemic communities.

In the United States, a comparatively low-context communication style prioritizes explicit and direct messaging. As Richard Fletcher et al. (2025) argue, the structural shift from television to social media has weakened the traditional credibility premium of legacy journalism. In this environment, politicians adopt high-authenticity formats, such as long-form podcasts and unscripted TikToks, which align with the ‘News Finds Me (NFM)’ dynamic. As a result, even passive audiences may increasingly rely on politically curated content, potentially reinforcing patterns of disengagement from institutional news sources.

IV. Methodology

This study employs a two-pronged research design combining comparative content analysis with theoretically guided case studies. This mixed approach is justified by the research questions: content analysis provides systematic pattern identification across a large corpus, while case studies illuminate the mechanisms and contextual logics that produce those patterns.

4.1 Comparative Content Analysis

This study employs a comparative content analysis of social media output from ten prominent politicians (five from each country), purposively sampled to reflect diverse party affiliations, genders, and career stages. The sampling frame captures the 2024 election cycles in both nations; April for South Korea and November for the United States, focusing on the peak periods of strategic trust-building.

To analyze how platform structures influence communication, data will be collected from each politician’s primary active channels: YouTube, Instagram, and KakaoTalk in South Korea, and X, TikTok, Instagram, and podcast transcripts in the United States. For each politician, 100 posts or videos per platform will be coded based on the following variables:

- Emotional appeal intensity (five-point scale: informational to high-affect emotional)
- Degree of personal disclosure (public-role content vs. private-life content)
- Interactivity signals (comments read aloud, viewer Q&A, live stream engagement)
- Authenticity markers (production quality as inverse proxy; unscripted speech indicators)

- Platform-native format use (Shorts, Reels, threads, story polls, etc.)

4.2 Case Studies

Two paired case studies will be conducted to illuminate the contextual logics and mechanisms of trust formation identified in the content analysis:

- **Korean Case:** The Structural Dominance of the Political YouTube Ecosystem (2020–2024)

This case examines how YouTube’s video-centric structure has become a primary alternative to legacy news in Korea. It focuses on how the platform’s capacity for long-form, high-affect content resonates with high-context cultural norms, allowing individual politicians to build deep relational credibility and “epistemic communities” among partisan audiences.

- **American Case:** Authenticity Performances in Podcast and TikTok Spaces (2024)

This case analyzes the politicization of non-political, fragmented platform spaces during the 2024 election cycle. It investigates how candidate appearances on long-form interview podcasts and unscripted TikToks function as “authenticity performances”.

The study explores how these low-context, direct-to-consumer formats bypass traditional journalistic gatekeeping to shift trust metrics among younger, news-avoidant voters.

4.3 Data Sources and Ethical Considerations

Social media post data will be collected via the YouTube Data API (v3) and Meta Content Library (pending access approval) for publicly available content. Podcast transcripts and TikTok content will be sampled through available public interfaces. All data involve public figures' public communications, and no personal identifying information about private individuals will be collected or analyzed.

Coding reliability will be established through inter-rater agreement testing with a minimum threshold of Cohen's kappa ≥ 0.75 .

V. Significance and Expected Contributions

This study makes contributions at three levels:

1) Theoretical Contribution

By integrating platform structural affordances with cross-cultural communication frameworks (e.g., High/Low-Context), this study proposes a conceptual framework for understanding political trust formation. It moves beyond single-variable explanations by demonstrating how media architecture and cultural norms are mutually constitutive. In particular, it contributes to comparative literature by examining how parasocial interaction (PSI) and audience cynicism (Markov & Min, 2023) operate differently across distinct digital ecosystems.

2) Empirical Contribution

The study constructs a cross-nationally comparable dataset of political social media content from South Korea and the United States, coded along dimensions such as affective intensity, authenticity markers, and platform-native formats. By incorporating data from the South Korean YouTube ecosystem alongside U.S. platform trends, this research helps address the relative lack of non-Anglophone data in political communication and offers a replicable framework for future comparative digital studies.

3) Policy and Practical Contribution

The findings provide insights into platform governance, particularly regarding the transparency of structural incentives that may shape perceptions of political trust. Furthermore, by identifying how ‘News Finds Me (NFM)’ perceptions relate to institutional news avoidance, the study offers implications for media literacy initiatives aimed at strengthening democratic resilience in platform-mediated communication environments.

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<문장 정제를 위해 활용. 연구자가 텍스트를 입력한 뒤 AI의 의견을 검토하여 일부 반영>